China in February 1972. In the past few years, however, the PRC has changed its political discourse to claim the legacy of the KMT as one of the victorious Allies of the Second World War, a founding member of the United Nations and one of the authors of its Charter. However, this has not resulted in any revision of the claim that the ‘century of humiliation’ came to an end not in 1945, at the end of the Second World War, but with the establishment of the PRC in 1949.

The term ‘century of humiliation’ was first used in 1915 in the popular opposition to the Yuan Shikai-led republican government meekly acquiescing to the infamous ‘Twenty-one Demands’ made by Japan (these twenty-one demands and other depredations China was subjected to will be described later in this chapter). The century it referred to began with the decline of the Qing empire after the death of its most successful ruler, Qianlong, in 1799. The succeeding Qing rulers presided over a polity beset with political, economic and cultural challenges, on a scale not encountered before. Later, the ‘century of humiliation’ began to be dated from the Opium Wars in the mid-nineteenth century.

Significant political, social and economic trends in the country at the end of the eighteenth century created a crisis of monumental proportions for the Qing empire, one of the most powerful empires in history in terms of area, population and the sheer scale of wealth under its authority. One of the key factors weakening the Qing empire was a series of domestic rebellions across the country. The first major one was the White Lotus rebellion, which began in 1794 and simmered on till 1820. The most devastating and widespread revolt was the Taiping rebellion, which erupted in 1850 and was defeated only in 1864. It was led by Hong Xiuquan, who claimed to be a younger brother of Jesus Christ, mandated to set up a Heavenly Kingdom of the Great Peace (Taiping Tianguo). The rebel forces were able to defeat the Qing forces in several engagements and succeeded, for a time, to establish an alternative kingdom with its capital at Nanjing. Hong Xiuquan declared himself king of the ‘Heavenly Kingdom’ and ordered the collective ownership of land. The rebel forces were only defeated by the Qing government relying on local forces of the Han gentry whose landholdings